

Windows Maximum Privacy Guide

Public guide for reducing Windows telemetry, consumer tracking, personalization, AI snapshot capture, cloud sync, advertising surfaces, and unnecessary app access while preserving updates and endpoint security.

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Release note

This v1.2 update rebuilds the guide for readability, raises the minimum content text size, replaces malformed bullet glyphs with plain ASCII bullets, adds quick-win guidance, and refreshes AI, browser, BitLocker, and maintenance tips.

Replace draft markings, capture review approval, and publish only from an approved GreyNOC channel.

Document Control

This page makes ownership, release state, limits, and change history visible before external distribution.

Field	Value	Notes
Title	Windows Maximum Privacy Guide	External-facing operational guide.
Document ID	GN-PUB-WINPRIV-001	Public Windows privacy baseline guide.
Classification	PUBLIC / APPROVED FOR EXTERNAL RELEASE AFTER REVIEW	Run communications, legal, security, and owner review before publication.
Owner	GreyNOC Cybersecurity Operations	Single accountable owner for technical accuracy and update cadence.
Approvers	Owner, Security, Communications, Legal as needed	Tailor to publication channel and client context.
Effective date	2026-06-13	Review when Windows settings, policy names, Microsoft privacy behavior, or Windows edition support changes.

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
v1.0	2026-06-12	GreyNOC	Initial public maximum privacy guide.
v1.1	2026-06-12	GreyNOC	Aligned to GreyNOC public template, added document control, release checklist, safer command boundaries, and verification structure.
v1.2	2026-06-13	GreyNOC	Readability rebuild: larger body/table/code text, cleaner bullets, revised quick-start flow, added practical tips, AI/Recall policy updates, extension and key-custody guidance, and refreshed sources.

Release rule

This document is public guidance, not legal advice. It must not include credentials, customer environments, live IPs, exploit instructions, internal-only toolchain details, unpublished capability claims, or customer-specific policy exports.

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Quick Wins

For most public users, do these first. Managed business devices should prefer Intune, Group Policy, or documented local policy after approval.

Priority	Action	Why it matters
1	Create restore point, confirm backup, and save BitLocker recovery key.	Protects the rollback path before privacy changes.
2	Turn off optional diagnostic data, personalized offers, advertising ID, activity history, and app-launch tracking.	Removes the highest-value optional OS personalization signals.
3	Disable Recall snapshots, Click to Do, Copilot where unsupported for the user role, and AI screen analysis.	Prevents screenshot and context-analysis exposure.
4	Stop OneDrive folder backup, Windows Backup preferences, and browser sync unless explicitly approved.	Prevents local settings from silently becoming cloud data.
5	Audit Edge extensions and site permissions.	Extensions and site permissions often outlive the reason they were granted.
6	Verify Windows Update, Defender, firewall, SmartScreen, and encryption still work.	Privacy hardening must not create a weaker endpoint.

Layered maximum privacy baseline

Reduce optional tracking without breaking patching, security, activation, certificates, time sync, licensing, or account authentication.

01 Executive Summary and Privacy Target

Before	After
Optional diagnostics, ad ID, suggestions, cloud sync, app permissions, AI capture, browser sync, and consumer surfaces may be enabled.	Optional items are off or minimized. Security, updates, Defender, firewall, BitLocker, SmartScreen, and required OS traffic stay on.

GreyNOC maximum privacy hardening reduces optional telemetry, consumer tracking, behavioral personalization, account-linked sync, AI screenshot capture, and unnecessary app access while keeping the Windows security floor intact. It is intended for public users who want the most private practical Windows configuration without modifying source code, patching operating system files, tampering with firmware, or changing hardware.

- Turn off optional diagnostic data, feedback prompts, satisfaction surveys, personalized offers, advertising ID, activity history, and app-launch tracking.
- Disable or restrict Recall, Click to Do, Copilot, Settings AI search, Paint AI features, screen capture, and content-analysis features not explicitly needed.
- Stop Microsoft account sync, Windows Backup preference sync, OneDrive folder backup, browser sync, and cross-device experiences unless intentionally approved.
- Deny location, camera, microphone, contacts, calendar, account info, app diagnostics, file system, screenshots, and background app access unless required by the user workflow.
- Disable Start recommendations, Search web/cloud content, Widgets, Windows Spotlight, Store suggestions, device usage personalization, post-update prompts, and similar consumer nudges.
- Keep Windows Update, Defender, firewall, SmartScreen, BitLocker, Secure Boot, certificate validation, time sync, licensing, and authentication paths functional.

Plain-language limit

No supported Windows configuration turns every Microsoft connection to zero. Required traffic can remain for updates, Defender intelligence, licensing, activation, certificate validation, account authentication, Store app updates, and required diagnostics depending on edition and configuration.

Privacy Profile Recommendation

Profile	Best for	Privacy posture	Security posture
Balanced privacy	Most home and small business users	Optional telemetry, ads, sync, suggestions, and app permissions reduced.	All Windows security controls stay enabled.
Maximum local privacy	Sensitive users, travel, legal, executive, incident workstations	Practical OS, app, AI, cloud sync, browser, and consumer surfaces off.	Security stack remains enabled; compatibility is tested.
Managed enterprise privacy	GreyNOC-managed or business fleets	Policies enforced by Intune, Group Policy, MDM, or documented local policy.	Centralized update, Defender, BitLocker, logging, and exception handling.

02 Before You Begin

Prepare the machine so hardening is reversible and so privacy changes do not accidentally remove security protections or data recovery paths.

Safety floor: do not trade security for privacy theater

Keep Windows Update, Defender, Firewall, SmartScreen, BitLocker, Secure Boot, certificate validation, activation, time sync, and required authentication paths enabled. Turn off optional telemetry, ads, Recall snapshots, suggestions, sync, unnecessary app access, and optional consumer experiences.

Prerequisites

- Use a supported Windows release. As of this v1.2 guide, free Windows 10 support ended on October 14, 2025; production systems should move to Windows 11 or a documented paid/support exception.
- Sign in as an administrator only when changing system policy. Use a standard account for daily work.
- Create a restore point or full backup before changing policy, registry, scheduled tasks, or service settings.
- Record the Windows edition, build number, account type, browser profile, BitLocker status, and endpoint protection status.
- For business devices, identify the device owner and approval path before changing managed settings.

Pre-flight Commands

```
# Run in Windows Terminal or PowerShell
winver
Get-ComputerInfo | Select-Object WindowsProductName, WindowsVersion, OsBuildNumber
Get-BitLockerVolume
Get-MpComputerStatus | Select-Object AMServiceEnabled, AntivirusEnabled,
RealTimeProtectionEnabled
Get-NetFirewallProfile | Select-Object Name, Enabled
```

Safety Checklist

Check	Expected result
Backup or restore point exists	The user can reverse accidental breakage.
BitLocker recovery key is stored safely	Device loss protection remains intact and recoverable.
Windows Update works	Quality, security, Defender, and driver updates can still install.
Defender, firewall, and SmartScreen are on	Privacy hardening does not create a weaker endpoint.
Business exceptions documented	Any setting left enabled has an owner, reason, and review date.

03 Manual Windows Settings Hardening

Use these steps first. Settings-based changes are safest for public users because they are visible, supportable, and easier to reverse.

Area	Path	Set to
Diagnostics	Settings > Privacy & security > Diagnostics & feedback	Optional diagnostic data Off. Delete diagnostic data. Feedback frequency Never where available.
Personalized offers	Settings > Privacy & security > Diagnostics & feedback; Recommendations & offers	Personalized offers, tailored experiences, recommendation tracking, and suggested Settings content Off.
Advertising ID	Settings > Privacy & security > General	Let apps show personalized ads by using advertising ID Off.
Language and app launch tracking	Settings > Privacy & security > General	Website access to language list Off. Let Windows improve Start and search by tracking app launches Off. Show suggested content Off.
Activity history	Settings > Privacy & security > Activity history	Store activity history Off. Clear history.
Location	Settings > Privacy & security > Location	Location services Off unless required. Clear default location. Review desktop apps separately.
Find my device	Settings > Privacy & security > Find my device	Off for highest privacy unless asset recovery is a higher priority.
Speech	Settings > Privacy & security > Speech	Online speech recognition Off unless required.
Inking and typing	Settings > Privacy & security > Inking & typing personalization	Custom dictionary/personalization Off. Clear personal dictionary where available.
Diagnostics app permission	Settings > Privacy & security > App diagnostics	Deny unless a trusted support app requires it.

Expected result

Windows stops optional diagnostic sharing where allowed, removes advertising identifiers, disables user-behavior personalization, clears stored local activity history, and denies unnecessary OS-level app access.

App Permissions Sweep

- Open Settings > Privacy & security > App permissions.
- Review Camera, Microphone, Voice activation, Notifications, Account info, Contacts, Calendar, Phone calls, Call history, Email, Tasks, Messaging, Radios, Other devices, App diagnostics, Documents, Downloads folder, Pictures, Videos, Music library, File system, and Screenshots and apps.
- Disable global access when the feature is not used. Otherwise leave global access on and deny individual apps that do not need it.

- Recheck permissions after installing new apps, browser extensions, conference tools, OEM utilities, VPN clients, password managers, or AI assistants.

Tip: desktop apps are different

Microsoft's privacy toggles mostly cover Microsoft Store style apps. Classic desktop apps may not appear in every per-app permission list, so review the app's own settings, startup behavior, browser hooks, and extension permissions too.

04 AI, Recall, Copilot, and Snapshot Controls

AI features can create or analyze screenshots, user content, prompts, browsing context, images, and app activity. Disable them unless the user intentionally accepts the data-handling model.

Control	Manual path / policy	Maximum privacy action
Recall snapshots	Settings > Privacy & security > Recall & snapshots; WindowsAI policy	Turn Save snapshots Off. Delete existing snapshots. For managed devices, disable Recall availability or saving snapshots where supported.
Recall export	WindowsAI AllowRecallExport where available	Deny export unless there is a documented, user-approved reason.
Click to Do	WindowsAI DisableClickToDo	Disable where supported. Treat it as screenshot and context analysis.
Copilot app	Settings > Apps > Installed apps; WindowsAI RemoveMicrosoftCopilotApp where supported	Uninstall or remove unless approved. Do not paste secrets, credentials, client records, or incident evidence into consumer AI.
Settings AI search	WindowsAI DisableSettingsAgent	Disable agentic Settings search on high-privacy systems when policy supports it.
Paint creative AI	WindowsAI DisableCocreator, DisableGenerativeFill, DisableImageCreator	Disable generative image features unless approved for the user role.
Screen capture permissions	Settings > Privacy & security > App permissions	Deny screenshot and screen capture access for apps that do not require it.

Managed-device Policy Direction

Policy names and availability vary by build, edition, ADMX, and MDM support.
Use Group Policy, Intune Settings Catalog, or Policy CSP where available.

Windows Components > Windows AI > Allow Recall to be enabled = Disabled
Windows Components > Windows AI > Turn off saving snapshots for use with Recall = Enabled
Windows Components > Windows AI > Disable Click to Do = Enabled
Windows Components > Windows AI > Disable Settings agentic search experience = Enabled

Policy CSP examples:

```
./Device/Vendor/MSFT/Policy/Config/WindowsAI/AllowRecallEnablement
./Device/Vendor/MSFT/Policy/Config/WindowsAI/DisableAIDataAnalysis
./Device/Vendor/MSFT/Policy/Config/WindowsAI/DisableClickToDo
./Device/Vendor/MSFT/Policy/Config/WindowsAI/RemoveMicrosoftCopilotApp
```

Public safety note

Do not rely on hiding a window, using a private browser tab, or minimizing an app as a privacy control if screen-analysis features are enabled. Disable capture at the operating-system, browser, app, or policy layer.

05 Cloud Sync, Accounts, Backup, and OneDrive

A privacy-hardened Windows machine should minimize account-linked sync. Local privacy settings are only part of the picture if the same user profile syncs documents, browsing data, preferences, passwords, or activity to cloud services.

Area	Path	Action
Microsoft account sign-in	Settings > Accounts > Your info	For maximum privacy, use a local account where appropriate. For business devices, use managed work identity instead of a personal Microsoft account.
Windows Backup	Settings > Accounts > Windows Backup	Turn Remember my apps and Remember my preferences Off unless intentionally approved.
OneDrive folder backup	OneDrive > Settings > Sync and backup > Manage backup	Stop backup for Desktop, Documents, Pictures, Music, and Videos unless using an approved tenant and retention model.
Linked devices	Microsoft account privacy dashboard and Devices page	Remove old devices and review app/account permissions.
Browser sync	Browser profile settings	Turn sync Off or use managed profile only. Avoid syncing passwords to personal accounts on business devices.
Microsoft 365 connected experiences	Office app privacy settings	Disable optional connected experiences and diagnostic data where user workflow allows.

BitLocker Recovery Key Custody

- Keep BitLocker or device encryption on. Privacy improves when lost or stolen devices remain encrypted.
- For public personal devices, store the recovery key in a safe offline location or trusted account.
- For company devices, recovery keys should be escrowed to the organization-controlled tenant, directory, or secure vault, not a personal account.
- Never enable encryption without a tested recovery path.

Cloud-sync Tips

Tip	Action
Separate identities	Do not mix personal Microsoft accounts, business tenants, and client work in one browser profile.
Download folder hygiene	Clear Downloads, Desktop, and Screenshots folders before enabling or testing cloud backup.
Password vault choice	Use an approved password manager rather than accidental browser sync to personal accounts.
Recovery key custody	Store BitLocker recovery keys where the device owner can recover them and where the organization can govern them.

06 App Permissions, Sensors, Clipboard, and Local Data

Least privilege applies to desktop privacy. Every app should receive only the local data, sensor, and background access it needs to perform its job.

Control	Maximum privacy setting	Validation idea
Camera and microphone	Deny globally unless needed; otherwise allow only trusted apps.	Open the conferencing app and confirm only the intended app works.
Voice activation	Off unless accessibility workflow requires it.	Check Privacy & security > Voice activation.
Notifications	Disable lock-screen notification content for sensitive users.	Lock the device and confirm content is hidden.
Contacts, calendar, email, tasks	Deny to apps that do not need account data.	Review app list after installing mail/calendar tools.
Documents, downloads, pictures, videos, music, file system	Deny broad library access unless the app truly needs it.	Open app permissions and confirm no broad access remains.
Clipboard history	Off for users handling secrets or client data. Sync across devices Off.	Press Windows + V and verify clipboard history behavior.
Nearby sharing	Off unless a documented device-trust workflow exists.	Check System > Nearby sharing.
Startup and background apps	Disable unnecessary startup and background permissions.	Task Manager > Startup apps; Settings > Apps.

Physical controls still matter

Webcam covers, microphone mute switches, privacy screens, automatic lock, short screen timeout, and clean-desk behavior reduce exposure beyond OS settings.

App Install Tripwires

Tripwire	What to check
Conference tools	Camera, mic, screen recording, background startup, cloud recording, calendar permissions.
OEM utilities	Telemetry, warranty prompts, driver assistants, account sign-in, background services.
PDF tools	Cloud upload, AI summarization, plugin stores, OCR retention, browser extension pairing.
Security tools	Keep endpoint protection on, but document cloud analysis, sample submission, and tenant ownership.

07 Browser, Edge, Search, Widgets, and Consumer Content

Windows privacy hardening is incomplete if the browser, search box, widgets, extensions, and consumer recommendation surfaces remain personalized.

Microsoft Edge Privacy Baseline

Edge area	Path	Action
Tracking prevention	edge://settings/privacy	Set to Strict after compatibility testing; use Balanced if sites break.
Optional diagnostics	Edge settings and Edge policies	Turn optional diagnostic data Off.
Personalization and ads	Privacy, search, and services	Turn off browsing-history personalization, shopping, coupons, price comparison, and similar consumer features.
Search suggestions	Address bar and search	Disable sending typed characters to search provider for sensitive users.
Sync	edge://settings/profiles/sync	Off unless using a managed profile and approved sync policy.
Extensions	edge://extensions	Remove coupon, shopping, search, screenshot, PDF, AI, VPN, and unknown extensions that can inspect pages. Use an allowlist.
SmartScreen	Privacy, search, and services	Keep SmartScreen On. It is a security control, not an ad feature.
Copilot page context	Edge policies	Disable Copilot page-context access where the user role does not need it.

Windows Consumer Surfaces

- Search permissions: turn off cloud content search and search history; disable search highlights where available.
- Taskbar: turn Widgets off unless the user wants consumer news, weather, sports, and stocks content.
- Personalization: replace Windows Spotlight on lock screen and desktop with a fixed local image.
- Start: turn off recommendations, recently added suggestions, account notifications, and tips.
- File Explorer: disable recommendations where exposed.
- Store and setup prompts: disable app suggestions, device usage personalization, and post-update setup prompts that ask users to connect more Microsoft services.

Browser Tips

Tip	Why
Use separate browser profiles	Separates personal sync, client work, admin portals, and disposable research.
Audit site permissions monthly	Camera, mic, location, notifications, clipboard, file handlers, USB/HID, and pop-ups can persist quietly.
Prefer installed password manager policy	Reduces unmanaged password sync and extension sprawl.
Keep phishing protection on	Do not disable SmartScreen just to reduce a network call.

08 Delivery Optimization, DNS, and Network Guardrails

Network controls should reduce unnecessary sharing without blocking the security and reliability traffic Windows needs to stay patched and trustworthy.

Area	Recommended setting	Do not break
Delivery Optimization	HTTP only or LAN-only. No internet peer-to-peer update sharing.	Windows Update and Defender intelligence updates.
DNS	Use a trusted resolver or GreyNOC-approved DNS filtering policy.	Certificate validation, authentication, update endpoints, and resolver reliability.
DNS over HTTPS	Use only if the resolver is trusted and policy-owned.	Do not bypass enterprise DNS logging/filtering without approval.
VPN	Use VPN on untrusted networks.	Do not route security services through unreliable tunnels that block updates.
Firewall	Public, Private, and Domain profiles enabled.	Do not allow broad inbound traffic just to make a legacy app work.
Microsoft endpoint blocking	Avoid broad blocks unless using a tested restricted-traffic baseline in an enterprise environment.	Activation, licensing, Store, Defender, Windows Update, SmartScreen, certificates, and time sync.
Random hardware addresses	Consider on public Wi-Fi if supported and compatible.	Do not break NAC, MDM, asset inventory, or allowed-device controls.

Delivery Optimization Steps

- Open Settings > Windows Update > Advanced options > Delivery Optimization.
- Turn Allow downloads from other PCs Off for the highest privacy setting.
- If a local fleet needs bandwidth savings, select Devices on my local network only, not internet peers.
- Confirm Windows Update and Microsoft Defender updates still work after changing this setting.

Tip: avoid brittle blocklists

A massive hosts file or firewall blocklist can look private while silently breaking activation, certificate checks, Defender intelligence, Store app updates, or support workflows. Prefer policy-backed controls and test results.

09 PowerShell and Registry Syntax

The commands below use supported Windows policy or preference locations. They avoid binary patching, OS file modification, kernel tampering, firmware changes, and hardware changes. Run as administrator only when changing HKLM policy keys.

Create a Restore Point First

```
# Run as Administrator
Checkpoint-Computer -Description "GreyNOC max privacy baseline" -RestorePointType
"MODIFY_SETTINGS"
```

Machine-level Policy Keys

```
# Run as Administrator when writing HKLM policy keys.
function Set-PolicyDword {
param(
[Parameter(Mandatory=$true)][string]$Path,
[Parameter(Mandatory=$true)][string]$Name,
[Parameter(Mandatory=$true)][int]$Value
)
New-Item -Path $Path -Force | Out-Null
Set-ItemProperty -Path $Path -Name $Name -Type DWord -Value $Value
}

$DataCollection = "HKLM:\SOFTWARE\Policies\Microsoft\Windows\DataCollection"
Set-PolicyDword $DataCollection "AllowTelemetry" 1
Set-PolicyDword $DataCollection "LimitDumpCollection" 1
Set-PolicyDword $DataCollection "LimitDiagnosticLogCollection" 1
Set-PolicyDword $DataCollection "DoNotShowFeedbackNotifications" 1

$CloudContent = "HKLM:\SOFTWARE\Policies\Microsoft\Windows\CloudContent"
Set-PolicyDword $CloudContent "DisableWindowsConsumerFeatures" 1
Set-PolicyDword $CloudContent "DisableSoftLanding" 1

$DeliveryOptimization = "HKLM:\SOFTWARE\Policies\Microsoft\Windows\DeliveryOptimization"
Set-PolicyDword $DeliveryOptimization "DODownloadMode" 0
```

Per-user Privacy Preferences

```
# Run in the user account you are hardening.
function Set-UserDword {
param([string]$Path, [string]$Name, [int]$Value)
New-Item -Path $Path -Force | Out-Null
Set-ItemProperty -Path $Path -Name $Name -Type DWord -Value $Value
}

Set-UserDword "HKCU:\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\AdvertisingInfo" "Enabled" 0
Set-UserDword "HKCU:\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\Advanced"
"Start_TrackProgs" 0
Set-UserDword "HKCU:\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\Advanced"
"Start_TrackDocs" 0
Set-UserDword "HKCU:\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\SearchSettings"
"IsDeviceSearchHistoryEnabled" 0
Set-UserDword "HKCU:\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\SearchSettings"
"IsDynamicSearchBoxEnabled" 0
Set-UserDword "HKCU:\Software\Microsoft\Clipboard" "EnableClipboardHistory" 0
Set-UserDword "HKCU:\Software\Microsoft\Clipboard" "CloudClipboardAutomaticUpload" 0
```

Disable Common Scheduled Feedback Tasks When Present

```
# These names vary by build. Commands are safe if the task does not exist.
Get-ScheduledTask |
Where-Object {$_.TaskName -match "Feedback|Siuf|Consolidator|UsbCeip"} |
Select-Object TaskPath, TaskName, State

# Review output first. Then disable only telemetry/feedback tasks you intentionally
selected.
# Example:
# Disable-ScheduledTask -TaskPath "\Microsoft\Windows\Feedback\Siuf\" -TaskName "DmClient"
```

Caution

Do not use random internet debloat scripts. Review every registry key, scheduled task, service change, firewall block, and app removal before running it.

10 Group Policy / Intune Policy Map

Managed devices should use policy instead of one-off clicks. Exact availability depends on Windows edition, build level, ADMX version, Intune templates, and licensing.

Control	Preferred managed setting	Notes
Diagnostic data	Data Collection and Preview Builds > Allow diagnostic data = Required or lowest supported level. MDM: System/AllowTelemetry.	Enterprise/Education may support stricter levels than Pro/Home.
Optional dumps and logs	Limit dump collection and Limit diagnostic log collection.	Reduces optional diagnostic detail.
Feedback prompts	Do not show feedback notifications.	Suppresses survey and satisfaction prompts.
Consumer experiences	Cloud Content policies to disable consumer features, soft landing, personalized suggestions, and Windows tips.	Confirm edition support.
Search and web results	Search policies for cloud content, web search, search highlights, and history.	Test Start and Search workflows.
Recall and snapshots	Windows AI policies to disable Recall enablement and saving snapshots.	Validate on Copilot+ PCs and supported builds.
Click to Do	Windows AI policy to disable Click to Do.	Treat as screen analysis.
Copilot app	WindowsAI CSP RemoveMicrosoftCopilotApp where supported.	Use only after confirming approved alternatives.
Delivery Optimization	HTTP only or LAN-only.	Updates must still work.
Edge	Edge policies: SmartScreen On, optional metrics Off, sync restricted, extension allowlist, Copilot page context restricted, tracking prevention.	Verify at edge://policy.
App permissions	Intune Settings Catalog privacy permissions for camera, mic, location, contacts, calendar, diagnostics, and file system.	Use role-based allowlists.
BitLocker	Escrow keys to Entra ID, Intune, AD, or approved vault.	Never rely on personal accounts for company devices.

11 Verification and Rollback

Verification is what turns a privacy checklist into an auditable baseline. Capture before/after evidence for managed or client devices.

Verification Commands

```
# Registry and policy spot checks
Get-ItemProperty "HKLM:\SOFTWARE\Policies\Microsoft\Windows\DataCollection" -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue
Get-ItemProperty "HKLM:\SOFTWARE\Policies\Microsoft\Windows\CloudContent" -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue
Get-ItemProperty "HKLM:\SOFTWARE\Policies\Microsoft\Windows\DeliveryOptimization" -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue
Get-ItemProperty "HKCU:\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\AdvertisingInfo" -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue
Get-ItemProperty "HKCU:\Software\Microsoft\Clipboard" -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue

# Security floor checks
Get-MpComputerStatus | Select-Object AntivirusEnabled, RealTimeProtectionEnabled, IoavProtectionEnabled
Get-NetFirewallProfile | Select-Object Name, Enabled
Get-BitLockerVolume

# Managed device evidence
gpreresult /h "$env:USERPROFILE\Desktop\greynoc-policy-result.html"
```

Manual Validation List

- Reboot once, sign in as the normal user, and confirm the machine still works.
- Windows Update can check, download, and install updates.
- Defender security intelligence updates and scans work.
- SmartScreen remains enabled in Windows Security and Edge.
- Diagnostics, feedback, advertising ID, activity history, cloud sync, app permissions, Recall, and browser sync reflect the intended state.
- OneDrive and Windows Backup behavior match the owner decision.
- Edge optional diagnostics, sync, tracking prevention, Copilot, extensions, and site permissions match the baseline.
- Exceptions are documented with owner, reason, compensating control, expiration, and rollback path.

Rollback Examples

```
# Remove example policy keys only when rollback is approved.
Remove-ItemProperty -Path "HKLM:\SOFTWARE\Policies\Microsoft\Windows\DataCollection"
-Name "AllowTelemetry" -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue
Remove-ItemProperty -Path "HKLM:\SOFTWARE\Policies\Microsoft\Windows\CloudContent" -Name
"DisableWindowsConsumerFeatures" -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue
Remove-ItemProperty -Path
"HKLM:\SOFTWARE\Policies\Microsoft\Windows\DeliveryOptimization" -Name
"DODownloadMode" -ErrorAction SilentlyContinue
gpupdate /force
Restart-Computer
```

12 Tips, Tricks, and Recurring Maintenance

Privacy drift usually comes from updates, new apps, browser extensions, setup prompts, and cloud sign-ins. Treat the baseline as a living configuration, not a one-time checklist.

When	Review
After Windows feature updates	Diagnostics, Recall/snapshots, Copilot, Settings AI, Edge policies, Widgets, Start recommendations, OneDrive backup, app permissions.
After installing apps	Startup entries, app permissions, browser extensions, protocol handlers, cloud sync prompts, background services.
Monthly	Edge extensions, site permissions, Microsoft account devices, privacy dashboard, OneDrive sync folders, Downloads/Desktop cleanup.
Before travel	Local account or managed account state, BitLocker key access, VPN, random hardware addresses, lock timeout, notification privacy, browser profiles.
Before client handoff	Proof pack: settings screenshots, command outputs, exceptions, restore path, source version, publication version.

Practical Tips

Tip	Practical move
Use a standard daily account	Reserve admin elevation for policy changes and software installation.
Create a separate browser profile for sensitive work	Keep sync, extensions, cookies, and history isolated from casual browsing.
Treat extensions as apps	Each extension can see, change, or exfiltrate browser data depending on permissions.
Use fixed lock-screen images	Avoid cloud-served Spotlight personalization and promotional surfaces.
Document exceptions	Every enabled convenience feature should have an owner, reason, review date, and rollback path.
Prefer policy over scripts on fleets	Policy is repeatable, auditable, reversible, and easier to support.

Small habit, big payoff

After every major update, search Settings for 'privacy', 'Recall', 'Copilot', 'backup', 'sync', 'recommendations', 'advertising', and 'activity'. Windows labels move, but search usually finds the new surface.

13 What Not to Disable

The settings below protect the user. Disabling them may reduce a visible connection but can make compromise, data loss, or identity theft more likely.

Keep enabled	Why it matters
Windows Update	Security patches, reliability fixes, and driver/firmware updates through approved channels.
Microsoft Defender Antivirus and security intelligence	Malware, phishing, script, and reputation protection.
Firewall profiles	Inbound exposure control on public, private, and domain networks.
SmartScreen and reputation-based protection	Warns about malicious sites, downloads, and potentially unwanted apps.
BitLocker or device encryption	Protects local data after loss or theft.
Secure Boot, TPM, Windows Hello	Protects boot integrity and credential material.
Certificate validation and root updates	Protects TLS and signed-code trust decisions.
Activation, licensing, and required auth endpoints	Keeps Windows and managed apps functioning.
Time synchronization	Security protocols and logs depend on accurate time.

Service-change caution

Do not randomly disable Connected User Experiences and Telemetry, Windows Error Reporting, Update Orchestrator, Defender, Store, licensing, or authentication services. If a business chooses service restrictions, test in a lab and document rollback.

14 Client Handoff Checklist

Use this checklist when delivering a hardened machine or public-facing support package.

Item	Pass / notes
Optional diagnostic data is off or at lowest supported level	
Feedback prompts and satisfaction surveys disabled where supported	
Advertising ID, activity history, app-launch tracking, and suggested content disabled	
Location and app permissions reviewed and minimized	
Recall snapshots, Click to Do, Copilot, and AI capture disabled where supported	
Cloud sync, OneDrive backup, Windows Backup preferences, and browser sync reviewed	
Edge privacy, SmartScreen, extensions, Copilot, site permissions, and tracking prevention configured	
Search, Widgets, Spotlight, Store suggestions, tips, and consumer experiences minimized	
Delivery Optimization internet peer-to-peer sharing disabled	
Windows Update, Defender, firewall, SmartScreen, BitLocker, and certificate validation verified	
Exceptions documented with owner and review date	
User understands remaining required Microsoft traffic and practical limits	

Suggested Client Wording

Client wording

GreyNOC reduced optional Windows diagnostic sharing, advertising personalization, consumer recommendations, AI snapshot capture, cloud sync, activity history, unnecessary app permissions, and browser personalization where the device allowed it. Security updates, endpoint protection, encryption, firewall, SmartScreen, and required reliability functions were left intact. Some Microsoft communication can still occur for licensing, updates, Defender, certificates, account authentication, required diagnostics, and approved app functionality.

15 Sources and Publication Notes

Public sources should be reviewed again before publication because Microsoft setting names and policy availability can change by Windows edition, build, and update channel. Sources below were reviewed for this v1.2 guide on June 13, 2026.

Source	URL
Diagnostics, feedback, and privacy in Windows	https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/diagnostics-feedback-and-privacy-in-windows-28808a2b-a31b-dd73-dcd3-4559a5199319
Privacy settings for Recommendations & offers in Windows 11	https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/privacy-settings-for-recommendations-offers-in-windows-11-807608ee-3de2-4498-8e7c-eb10d655567f
Windows activity history and your privacy	https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/windows-activity-history-and-your-privacy-2b279964-44ec-8c2f-e0c2-6779b07d2cbd
Windows privacy settings that apps use	https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/windows-privacy-settings-that-apps-use-8b7f2cf4-c359-bf99-0f69-2123cc9ddf1
Microsoft Edge, browsing data, and privacy	https://support.microsoft.com/en-US/edge/microsoft-edge-browsing-data-and-privacy
Configure Windows diagnostic data in your organization	https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/privacy/configure-windows-diagnostic-data-in-your-organization
Manage connections from Windows operating system components to Microsoft services	https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/privacy/manage-connections-from-windows-operating-system-components-to-microsoft-services
WindowsAI Policy CSP	https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/client-management/mdm/policy-csp-windowsai
Microsoft Edge policies	https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/deployedge/microsoft-edge-policies
Delivery Optimization reference	https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/deployment/do/waas-delivery-optimization-reference
Find your BitLocker recovery key	https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/find-your-bitlocker-recovery-key-6b71ad27-0b89-ea08-f143-056f5ab347d6
Microsoft Privacy Statement	https://privacy.microsoft.com/privacystatement

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